of Assam'.[15] It was interpreted to mean that the North East would be abandoned and is still strongly resented by the Assamese.

Then, as suddenly as they had come, the Chinese declared a unilateral ceasefire and withdrew roughly to their pre-war position. We still do not know for sure why they came in and why they left. The most likely reason is that winter was fast approaching and supply lines through the Himalayas would have been difficult to sustain. In the end, nature proved a better defender of the Indian Republic than its politicians. Today, the road from Tezpur to Bomdila is a beautiful drive through dense forests and high mountains. In the lower reaches, wild elephants often hold up traffic. From Bomdila, one can carry on through Sela Pass (4200 metres above sea level) to the monastery at Tawang. Still, the memory of the Chinese invasion lingers. Convoys of army trucks make their way up the mountains to supply military bases that dot the region. The Chinese, too, have not forgotten the past. They still mark the province as 'Southern Tibet' in their maps and made an awful fuss when the Dalai Lama visited Tawang in 2009.

The war had left thousands of Indian soldiers dead or wounded. Nehru's personal reputation lay shattered. The removal of Defence Minister Menon, Lt. General Kaul and army chief General Pran Nath Thapar could not hide Nehru's own strategic miscalculations. As 1963 dragged on, everyone became aware of the obvious—Prime Minister Nehru was an old man who had been in power for sixteen years. History appeared to be repeating itself: an ageing leader who had been on the throne for a long time, unclear succession and war. Indeed, the sixties was a time of great uncertainty. Nehru died in 1964, Pakistan and India fought a war in 1965, Nehru's successor Shastri died in January 1966, the Congress Party split and the economy stagnated.

Out of all this, Nehru's daughter Indira Gandhi emerged as prime minister. In the early seventies, she would play an important role in a major shift in the political geography of the subcontinent.

BANGLADESH